

MERIDIAN HEALTH PLAN — MEDICAL POLICY MP-RAD-014

Advanced Imaging: Lumbar Spine MRI | Effective 2026-01-01 | Revision 7

1. Purpose

This policy establishes medical necessity criteria for magnetic resonance imaging (MRI) of the lumbar spine for members enrolled in commercial plans.

2. Criteria — Medically Necessary

Lumbar spine MRI is considered **medically necessary** when **ANY ONE** of the following criteria (2.1 through 2.4) is met and documented in the medical record:

- **2.1** Low back pain persisting six (6) weeks or longer that has failed a documented trial of conservative therapy, where conservative therapy includes at least one of: physical therapy, NSAID or analgesic pharmacotherapy, or a supervised home exercise program.
- **2.2** Presence of any red-flag finding, including progressive neurologic deficit, suspected cauda equina syndrome, suspected malignancy, or suspected spinal infection. Red-flag presentations are exempt from the conservative therapy requirement in 2.1.
- **2.3** Radicular pain persisting four (4) weeks or longer, with corresponding objective neurologic findings on physical examination (for example, diminished deep tendon reflex, dermatomal sensory loss, or motor weakness).
- **2.4** Pre-operative planning where lumbar spine surgery is being actively considered by a treating surgeon.

3. Criteria — Not Medically Necessary

Lumbar spine MRI is considered **not medically necessary** for acute low back pain of less than six (6) weeks duration in the absence of red-flag findings as defined in 2.2.

4. Documentation Requirements

The medical record must document: duration of symptoms; the specific conservative therapy modalities attempted and their duration; objective physical examination findings; and the clinical question the imaging is expected to answer.

5. Appeals

A denial under this policy may be appealed in writing within one hundred eighty (180) days of the denial notice. A peer-to-peer review with a plan medical director may be requested within fourteen (14) days.